

Cultural Threads: An Overview of Research on Fashion, Heritage & Integration

LITERATURE REVIEW

Prepared for:

Date: 24/10/2025

Keywords: Cultural heritage, identity integration, diaspora, art therapy, pattern cutting, consumption behaviour

CONTENTS

1.0 Introduction

1.1 *Reminder of Client Overview*

2.0 Review

2.1 *Cultural Connection & Healing*

2.2 *Impacts of Creativity on Psychological Integration & Cultural Connection*

2.3 *Identity, Belonging, & Consumption*

3.0 Synthesis

4.0 Conclusion

5.0 References

1.0 INTRODUCTION

In recent years, creative practices as a method of psychological therapy have been rigorously researched, examined, and applied across diverse contexts. This emergence, coinciding with the 21st-century rise in psychological awareness and the broader “self-help” renaissance, has contributed to the global implementation of art therapies in settings such as care homes (Ching-Teng et al., 2019), educational institutions (Regev et al., 2015), cancer treatment (Nainis et al., 2006), employee wellbeing and stress management programs (Visnola et al., 2010), and mood disorder interventions (Shukla et al., 2022). The growing body of research and practical application surrounding creative activities - often dismissed colloquially as mere “hobbies” - underscores their genuine psychological and even medical value (McNiff, 1992), suggesting that the act of creating may offer far more than leisure; it may serve as a legitimate route to psychological restoration.

While the research landscape is encouraging, the field, like many areas of psychology, becomes increasingly complex when individual differences are taken into account. One of the most significant confounding variables in relation to self-identity and self-expression, both central to psychological rehabilitation (Lanius et al., 2020), is the experience of fragmented or hybrid identity due to diaspora and/or dual heritage (Shaff et al., 2024). This factor is significant as it holds particular relevance for psychologically vulnerable populations such as refugees as well as other migrant groups. Scholarship addressing this intersection has grown steadily since the 1990s and continues to hold critical importance today, particularly against the backdrop of ongoing geopolitical crises such as the Ukraine–Russia conflict and the sustained colonial violence in Palestine.

Beyond clinical and refugee contexts, however, it is valuable to understand how dual or multiple cultural identities interact with creative therapeutic practice in a broader sense. As art is traditionally rooted in, and often inextricably linked to, culture, the process of exploring heritage through creative activity carries the potential to foster both cultural integration and reconnection (Marshall, 2007). This area of research remains underdeveloped, yet preliminary studies indicate that creative engagement can support emotional resilience and promote bicultural identity, particularly among individuals who have experienced relocation and cultural transition (Eng et al., 2005; Benartzy, 2020).

In light of these findings, it is worth considering how creative practices that are inherently material, embodied, and culturally embedded - such as fashion design and garment construction - might serve a similar therapeutic function. As forms of making that are simultaneously expressive, social, and rooted in tradition, they carry the potential to reconnect individuals with cultural narratives that are both personal and

collective. Fashion, in particular, occupies a unique position at the crossroads of identity and culture: garments are not only physical manifestations of self-expression but also bearers of cultural heritage and social belonging (Safdar et al., 2020). Engaging with such practices may therefore offer a distinct avenue for psychological integration - allowing individuals to externalise and reconstruct fragmented aspects of identity through tactile creation.

Considering this contextual introduction, the present report aims to provide a high-level overview of relevant literature and the existing cross-disciplinary relationships between art, culture, and psychology. The discussion will begin with an assessment of cultural connection and its potential role in psychological healing, followed by a brief analysis of creativity and its impacts on integration and cultural connection. The final section of the review will consider the broader implications of these findings, particularly in relation to consumer behaviour and fashion consumption. The report will conclude with a synthesis of the reviewed literature and a compact reflection on possible avenues for future empirical research within these intersecting fields.

1.1 Client Overview

This section restates the client overview and research questions from the Research Request Form. It should serve as a reference point for the review, ensuring that all key aims are addressed.

Client Description

To explore how being connected to our heritage and culture, (especially for those who have been raised between cultures), through pattern cutting and garment creation can impact our psyche; integrate fragmented parts of ourselves that haven't felt like they've fitted in or belonged. Does this impact levels of contentment, fulfilment, creativity and happiness? And does this have a ripple effect towards our loved ones, family, friends, community?

Aims/Research Questions

1. Does pattern cutting with the intention to connect to one's heritage and culture create a pathway for intergenerational and emotional healing?
2. What happens psychologically and socially when 'fashion design' becomes a tool for cultural reconnection and self-integration? If there was more 'research/theory' around this, could it have a positive impact on overconsumption?
3. What happens to buying and spending habits when one is rooted in their identity, sense of belonging, expression and connected to their heritage and culture?

2.0 REVIEW

The next section of the report will consist of the literature review. Please bear in mind that the research questions innately touch a wide range of research areas and therefore, in a report of this brevity, not all lines of academic inquiry can be covered.

2.1 Cultural Connection & Healing

Existing research highlights the significance of cultural reconnection as a process through which individuals and communities negotiate identity, belonging, and emotional repair. For those with dual heritage or diasporic identities, reconnecting with ancestral culture can foster a sense of coherence and continuity, mitigating the effects of displacement and intergenerational trauma (Bloch & Hirsch, 2018; Urrieta, 2019). Within diasporic contexts, cultural engagement has been linked to emotional resilience, facilitating both personal and familial healing through the reaffirmation of shared narratives and values (Quayle & Sonn, 2019). Studies examining Indigenous and Black diasporic experiences suggest that cultural revival and creative self-expression can function as therapeutic practices, enabling intergenerational dialogue and the reparation of historical wounds (Swain, 2019; Williamson, 2017).

Creative and craft-based activities have been proven to serve as mediators in this process, offering tangible forms through which memory, identity, and emotion can be externalised and reworked. Textile work, storytelling, and other forms of making have been shown to help participants articulate hybrid or fragmented identities while reclaiming agency over their cultural histories (Bisht, 2023; Kieser, 2024). In terms of activities relevant to garment construction, practices such as paper-cutting and sewing, have been used to embed cultural symbolism into acts of creation, transforming craft into a site of emotional restoration (Has, 2024; Williamson, 2017). While there is currently no research that directly examines pattern cutting as a mode of cultural or emotional healing, its parallels with other textile-based practices suggest it may hold similar potential for facilitating reconnection and repair within diasporic or dual-heritage contexts.

Furthermore, Elaine Scarry's seminal work, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World* (1985), provides a more explicitly philosophical perspective on trauma, offering further insight into the potential of pattern cutting. Scarry argues that pain and trauma can "unmake" the world by disrupting the ways in which we perceive and make sense of reality. Conversely, acts of creation, the process of making, serve as a restorative counterpoint, rebuilding the perceptual and symbolic structures compromised by trauma. In this context, pattern cutting and garment construction, as

tangible acts of cutting, shaping, and reassembling materials, can be understood as material metaphors for this process of reconstruction.

2.2 Impacts of Creativity on Psychological Integration & Cultural Connection

Research suggests that engagement in creative practices, such as pattern cutting, fashion design, and textile work, may support aspects of psychological integration and cultural reconnection, particularly for individuals navigating dual heritage or diasporic identities. As alluded to in the previous section, such activities are thought to provide a tangible and embodied medium through which participants can explore cultural identity, express personal narratives, and negotiate multiple cultural influences (Gjoni, 2025; Pop et al., 2018). While evidence remains largely qualitative or exploratory, these creative processes have been associated with facilitating self-expression and a sense of coherence, which could contribute to emotional well-being (Musa, 2020; Has, 2024).

The act of creating within a culturally informed framework may allow participants to externalise experiences and reflect on fragmented aspects of identity. For instance, pattern cutting and garment construction involve processes of deconstruction and reassembly, which some authors suggest could function as material metaphors for reorganising or integrating aspects of the self (Zou, 2022; Williamson, 2017) - these findings align with Scarry's theoretical observations outlined above. Similarly, incorporating cultural motifs or techniques into fashion design may provide opportunities for engaging with heritage, though the extent and nature of any psychological or cultural effects remain tentative (Pop et al., 2018; Musa, 2020).

Overall, the literature implies that creative engagement can offer a potential avenue for connecting with culture and exploring identity. However, findings are extremely context-dependent, and there is limited empirical work specifically examining pattern cutting or fashion design as mechanisms for psychosocial integration. These practices should therefore be considered as promising areas for further investigation rather than established interventions for cultural or emotional healing.

2.3 Identity, Belonging, & Consumption

Existing research suggests that individuals' relationships with their cultural heritage can significantly influence their consumption practices, particularly when heritage becomes a salient component of self-identity. Studies within consumer culture theory propose that consumption is often a means of identity negotiation and self-expression rather than merely an economic act (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). This is especially relevant for individuals with dual or diasporic identities, who may use consumption to reconcile or perform different aspects of cultural belonging (Üstüner & Holt, 2007). This aligns with Askegaard et al's (2005) notion of "consumer acculturation," which describes how

diasporic consumers use material culture and symbolic goods to mediate between multiple cultural identities.

Scholars have also observed that reconnecting with one's heritage through creative or cultural practices can alter the symbolic meanings attached to consumption. For instance, fashion design and 'dressing up' have been theorised as performative acts through which identity and heritage are negotiated (Craik, 2024). Crane and Bovone (2006) similarly argue that fashion consumption can serve as a communicative medium through which individuals construct narratives of belonging and authenticity. This suggests a potential overlap between the creative processes discussed in sections above, such as pattern cutting, and consumption practices that express or reinforce identity. However, empirical research directly linking levels of heritage connection to consumption behaviours remains limited, particularly in creative contexts such as garment construction.

In diasporic contexts, consumption can serve both reparative and resistive functions. Studies from the 90s have highlighted how consumption practices among transnational and immigrant communities often operate as strategies of cultural maintenance or reassertion in the face of displacement (Thompson & Tambyah, 1999; Penalosa, 1994). This implies that purchasing or producing culturally resonant artefacts can symbolically restore a sense of self-continuity disrupted by migration or colonisation. Oswald (1999) further develops this through her work on "culture swapping," where consumers navigate between cultural repertoires in pursuit of coherence and self-integration. Yet, while these studies underscore the significance of heritage in shaping symbolic consumption, the emotional and psychological mechanisms underlying this connection, particularly its potential healing dimension, remain underexplored.

In this respect, integrating insights from material culture theory and psychology may provide a fuller understanding. The act of choosing, creating, or wearing culturally meaningful objects may serve as a form of embodied remembrance or symbolic repair, echoing arguments from earlier sections regarding creative reconstruction and self-integration (Scarry, 1985; van der Kolk, 2014). Moreover, Chattaraman & Lennon (2018) suggests that heritage-inspired fashion can foster a sense of cultural continuity that mitigates feelings of dislocation common among bicultural individuals. Nonetheless, the extent to which such practices translate into measurable changes in consumption or spending behaviour remains largely speculative, highlighting a critical gap in interdisciplinary literature.

3.0 SYNTHESIS

Across the reviewed literature, a consistent narrative emerges around the transformative potential of creative and culturally rooted practices—such as garment construction and pattern cutting—as pathways for identity integration, cultural reconnection, and emotional repair. Studies of diasporic and dual-heritage experiences show that reconnecting with ancestral culture through embodied, creative acts can restore coherence to fragmented identities, offering both individual and intergenerational healing (Bloch & Hirsch, 2018; Urrieta, 2019; Williamson, 2017). Pattern cutting, though not yet directly studied in this context, appears conceptually aligned with other textile-based practices that externalise memory and emotion, functioning as metaphors for reconstructing the self after trauma (Scarry, 1985; Has, 2024). Creativity is repeatedly shown to enable participants to express, negotiate, and integrate multiple cultural influences, suggesting that fashion design may indeed operate as a form of psychological and cultural therapy (Musa, 2020; Zou, 2022). This process of reconnection also bears implications for patterns of consumption: as individuals become more rooted in cultural identity and belonging, the symbolic meanings of consumption shift from surface-level acquisition toward deeper expressions of heritage and authenticity (Craig, 2024; Arnould & Thompson, 2005). While evidence remains largely qualitative, the reviewed research collectively supports the notion that fashion design, when intentionally directed toward heritage engagement, can foster emotional integration and potentially reduce overconsumption by cultivating fulfillment and cultural continuity. In responding to the client's aims, the literature suggests that pattern cutting has untapped potential as a psychosocial tool—one that bridges creativity, identity, and community through acts of making that both heal and reimagine belonging.

4.0 CONCLUSION

In summary, the literature suggests that creative, culturally rooted practices can support healing, belonging, and self-integration, though direct research on pattern cutting remains limited. This gap presents an opportunity to explore how garment creation might act as both a psychological and cultural tool—strengthening identity, fostering wellbeing, and potentially encouraging more meaningful, less consumptive relationships with fashion and heritage.

Word Count excl. Client Overview: 2031

5.0 REFERENCES

Introduction

Benartzy, A. (2020). *Place-based intercultural liminality and the potential of art therapy in cultural identity negotiations*.

Ching-Teng, Y., Ya-Ping, Y., & Yu-Chia, C. (2019). Positive effects of art therapy on depression and self-esteem of older adults in nursing homes. *Social Work in Health Care*, 58(3), 324–338. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00981389.2018.1564108>

Eng, T., Kuiken, D., Temme, K., & Sharma, R. (2005). Navigating the emotional complexities of two cultures: Bicultural competence, feeling expression, and feeling change in dreams. *Journal of Cultural and Evolutionary Psychology*, 3(3–4), 267–285. <https://doi.org/10.1556/JCEP.3.2005.3-4.6>

Lanius, R. A., Terpou, B. A., & McKinnon, M. C. (2020). The sense of self in the aftermath of trauma: Lessons from the default mode network in posttraumatic stress disorder. *European Journal of Psychotraumatology*, 11(1), 1807703. <https://doi.org/10.1080/20008198.2020.1807703>

Marshall, C. M. (2007). Cultural identity, creative processes, and imagination: Creating cultural connections through art making. *Journal of Cultural Research in Art Education*, 25, 1–13.

McNiff, S. (1992). *Art as medicine: Creating a therapy of the imagination*. Shambhala Publications.

Nainis, N., Paice, J. A., Ratner, J., Wirth, J. H., Lai, J., & Shott, S. (2006). Relieving symptoms in cancer: Innovative use of art therapy. *Journal of Pain and Symptom Management*, 31(2), 162–169. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpainsymman.2005.07.006>

Regev, D., Green-Orlovich, A., & Snir, S. (2015). Art therapy in schools: The therapist's perspective. *The Arts in Psychotherapy*, 45, 47–55. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.aip.2015.05.003>

Safdar, S., Goh, K., & Choubak, M. (2020). Clothing, identity, and acculturation: The significance of immigrants' clothing choices. *Canadian Journal of Behavioural Science / Revue canadienne des sciences du comportement*, 52(1), 36–46. <https://doi.org/10.1037/cbs0000139>

Shaff, J., Wang, X., Cubbage, J., Bandara, S., & Wilcox, H. C. (2024). Mental health and multiracial/ethnic adults in the United States: A mixed methods participatory action

investigation. *Frontiers in Public Health*, 11, 1286137.
<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2023.1286137>

Shukla, A., Choudhari, S. G., Gaidhane, A. M., Syed, Z. Q., & Gaidhane, A. (2022). Role of art therapy in the promotion of mental health: A critical review. *Cureus*, 14(8), e28003. <https://doi.org/10.7759/cureus.28003>

Visnola, D., Sprudza, D., Arija, M. B., & Pike, A. (2010). Effects of art therapy on stress and anxiety of employees. *Proceedings of the Latvian Academy of Sciences*, 64(1–2), 85–91. <https://doi.org/10.2478/v10046-010-0024-5>

Review

Cultural Connection & Healing

Bisht, P. (2023). *Animating memory: Creative explorations of postcolonial memories and identities in the British Bangladeshi diaspora*. *Animation Practice, Process & Production*, 12(1), 77–93. https://doi.org/10.1386/ap3_00046_1

Bloch, A., & Hirsch, S. (2018). *Inter-generational transnationalism and refugee backgrounds*. *Comparative Migration Studies*, 6(1), 1–16.
<https://doi.org/10.1186/s40878-018-0096-0>

Has, M. (2024). *Crafting culture in early childhood: Integrating paper cutting as an intangible cultural heritage into educational curricula*. *Pacific International Journal*, 6 (4) <https://doi.org/10.55014/pij.v6i4.542>

Kieser, A. (2024). *Revealing intergenerational traits and self-compassion through therapeutic creation*. *South African Journal of Art Therapy*, 2(1), 33–48.
<https://journals.uj.ac.za/index.php/sajat/article/view/3350>

Quayle, A., & Sonn, C. (2019). *Amplifying the voices of Indigenous elders through community arts and narrative inquiry: Stories of oppression, psychosocial suffering, and survival*. *American Journal of Community Psychology*, 2 (64), 46-58. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph16183402>

Scarry, E. (2014). *The body in pain: The making and unmaking of the world*. Oxford University Press. (Original work published 1985)

Swain, A. (2019). *The healing power of art in intergenerational trauma: Race, sex, age, and disability*. *Canadian Journal of Disability Studies*, 8(2), 22–39.
<https://doi.org/10.15353/cjds.v8i2.469>

Urrieta, L. (2019). *Indigenous reflections on identity, trauma, and healing: Navigating belonging and power*. *Genealogy*, 3(2), 26.
<https://doi.org/10.3390/genealogy3020026>

Williamson, J. (2017). *The Sewing Circle Project: Reflections on ten years*. *Journal of Family and Environmental Studies*, 5(3), 14–27.
<https://jfepublications.org/article/sewing-circle-project>

Impacts of Creativity on Psychological Integration & Cultural Connection

Gjoni, A. (2025). The influence of fashion on identity and aesthetics: Exploring the dual role of fashion as self-expression and cultural construct. *SDGs Review*, 1(1), 1–10.
<https://sdgsreview.org/LifestyleJournal/article/download/6116/2830/17094>

Has, M. (2024). Crafting culture in early childhood: Integrating paper cutting as an intangible cultural heritage into educational curricula. *Pegem Journal of Education and Instruction*, 14(2), 88–102.
<https://doi.org/10.14527/pegegog.2024.542>

Musa, Z. (2020). The impact of motifs and patterns on surface design in fashion and textile design on people's emotions. *ResearchGate*.
<https://www.researchgate.net/publication/340314821>

Williamson, J. (2017). *The Sewing Circle Project: Reflections on ten years*. *Journal of Family and Environmental Studies*, 5(3), 14–27.
<https://jfepublications.org/article/sewing-circle-project>

Pop, M., Manea, I., & Andronache, B. (2018). Cultural Identity in Product Design of Fashion Technology–Tools and Method. In ICAMS Proceedings of the International Conference on Advanced Materials and Systems (pp. 229–234).

Zou, Y. (2022). Evaluation and trend of fashion design research: Visualization and analysis. *Fashion and Textiles*, 9(1), 1–15.
<https://fashionandtextiles.springeropen.com/articles/10.1186/s40691-022-00316-6>

Identity, Belonging, & Consumption

Arnould, E. J., & Thompson, C. J. (2005). Consumer culture theory (CCT): Twenty years of research. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 31(4), 868–882.

Askegaard, S., Arnould, E. J., & Kjeldgaard, D. (2005). Postassimilationist ethnic consumer research: Qualifications and extensions. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 32(1), 160–170.

Chattaraman, V., & Lennon, S. J. (2008). Ethnic identity, consumption of cultural apparel, and self-perceptions of ethnic consumers. *Journal of Fashion Marketing and Management: An International Journal*, 12(4), 518–531.

Craik, J. (2024). *Fashion: the key concepts*. Bloomsbury Publishing.

Crane, D., & Bovone, L. (2006). Approaches to material culture: The sociology of fashion and clothing. *Poetics*, 34(6), 319–333.

Oswald, L. R. (1999). Culture swapping: Consumption and the ethnogenesis of middle-class Haitian immigrants. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 25(4), 303–318.

Penaloza, L. (1994). Atravesando fronteras/border crossings: A critical ethnographic exploration of the consumer acculturation of Mexican immigrants. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 21(1), 32–54.

Scarry, E. (1985). *The body in pain: The making and unmaking of the world*. Oxford University Press.

Thompson, C. J., & Tambyah, S. K. (1999). Trying to be cosmopolitan. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 26(3), 214–241.

Üstüner, T., & Holt, D. B. (2007). Dominated consumer acculturation: The social construction of poor migrant women's consumer identity projects in a Turkish squatter. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 34(1), 41–56.

van der Kolk, B. (2014). *The body keeps the score: Brain, mind, and body in the healing of trauma*. Penguin Books.